

SGA's MVP Case

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Shai Gilgeous-Alexander

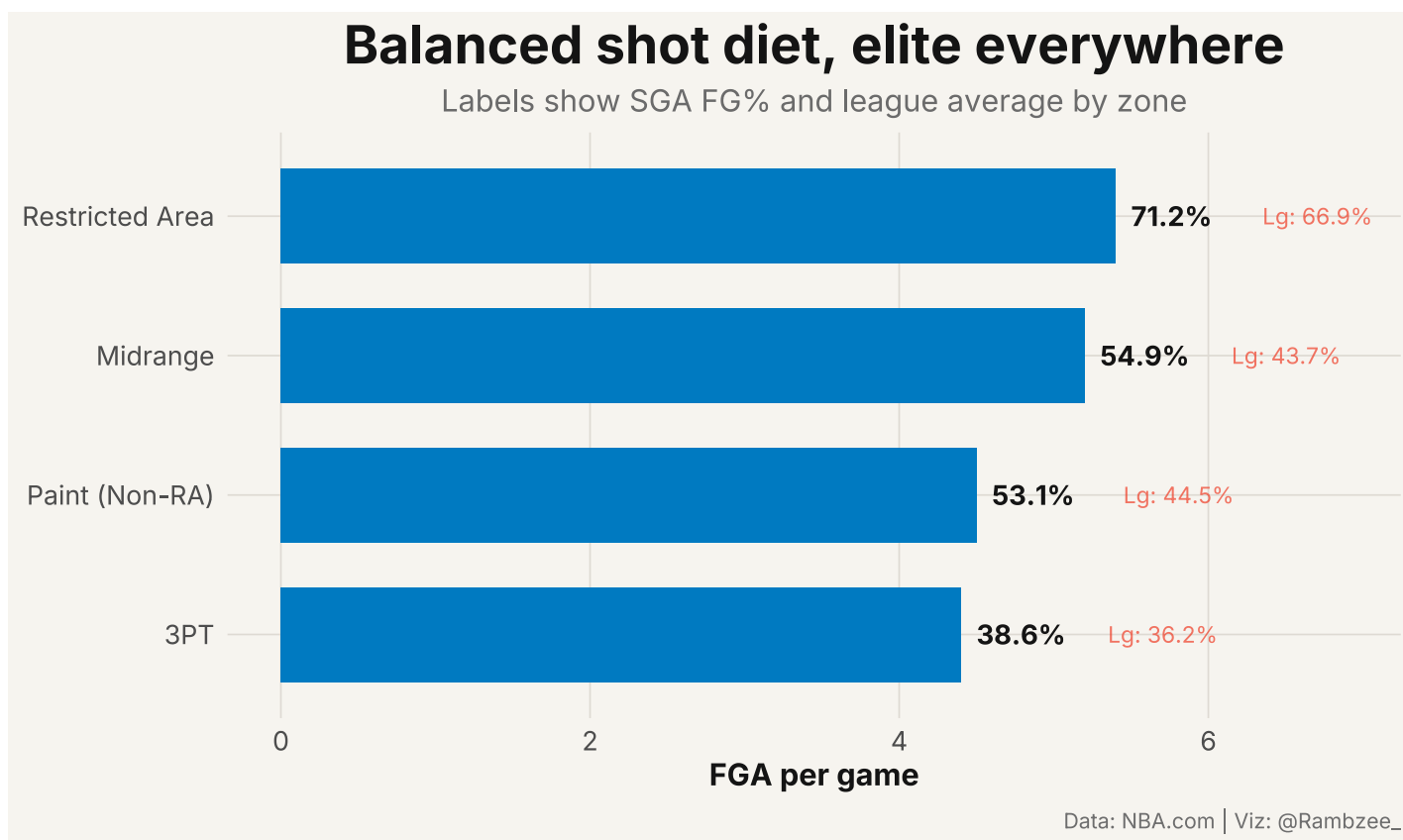
The Case

Shai Gilgeous-Alexander is not just putting up MVP numbers. He is having one of the most efficient high-volume scoring seasons a guard has ever produced.

He is averaging 31.1 points per game on +8.4 rTS, controlling the middle of the floor, taking care of the ball at a historically rare level for this kind of volume, and anchoring elite offense for the best team in the league. Coming off a championship and Finals MVP, Shai has built about as complete an MVP case as you could ask for.

Scoring Profile

Zone	Pct	Volume	Context
Restricted Area	71.2%	5.4 att/G	+4.3 rFG%
Paint (Non-RA)	53.1%	4.5 att/G	+8.6 rFG%
Midrange	54.9%	5.2 att/G	+11.2 rFG%
3PT	38.6%	4.4 att/G	+2.4 rFG%
FT	87.9%	9.0 FTA/G	46.5% FTr



Shai is not just living off one zone or one coverage. What stands out first is how different his athleticism looks from almost anyone else. He does not overpower people in the usual way. He stretches, slithers, changes angles, and gets to the rim whenever he wants. It often feels like he glides from one spot to another without ever giving the defender a clean body line.

That is what makes this season so difficult to defend. No single defender can really handle him, and no coverage holds up for long because he demands the attention of the entire defense. He is an isolation savant who can beat his man clean, force extra help, and then punish whatever comes next. Send two and he finds the open man or slips through the gap himself. Stay home and he picks the matchup apart. Switch, hedge, blitz, drop, eventually he solves it. That is why the shot profile looks the way it does. He is not efficient everywhere by accident. He gets there because defenses have to load up on him, and even then he still has the counter.

Pressure, Load, and Scalability

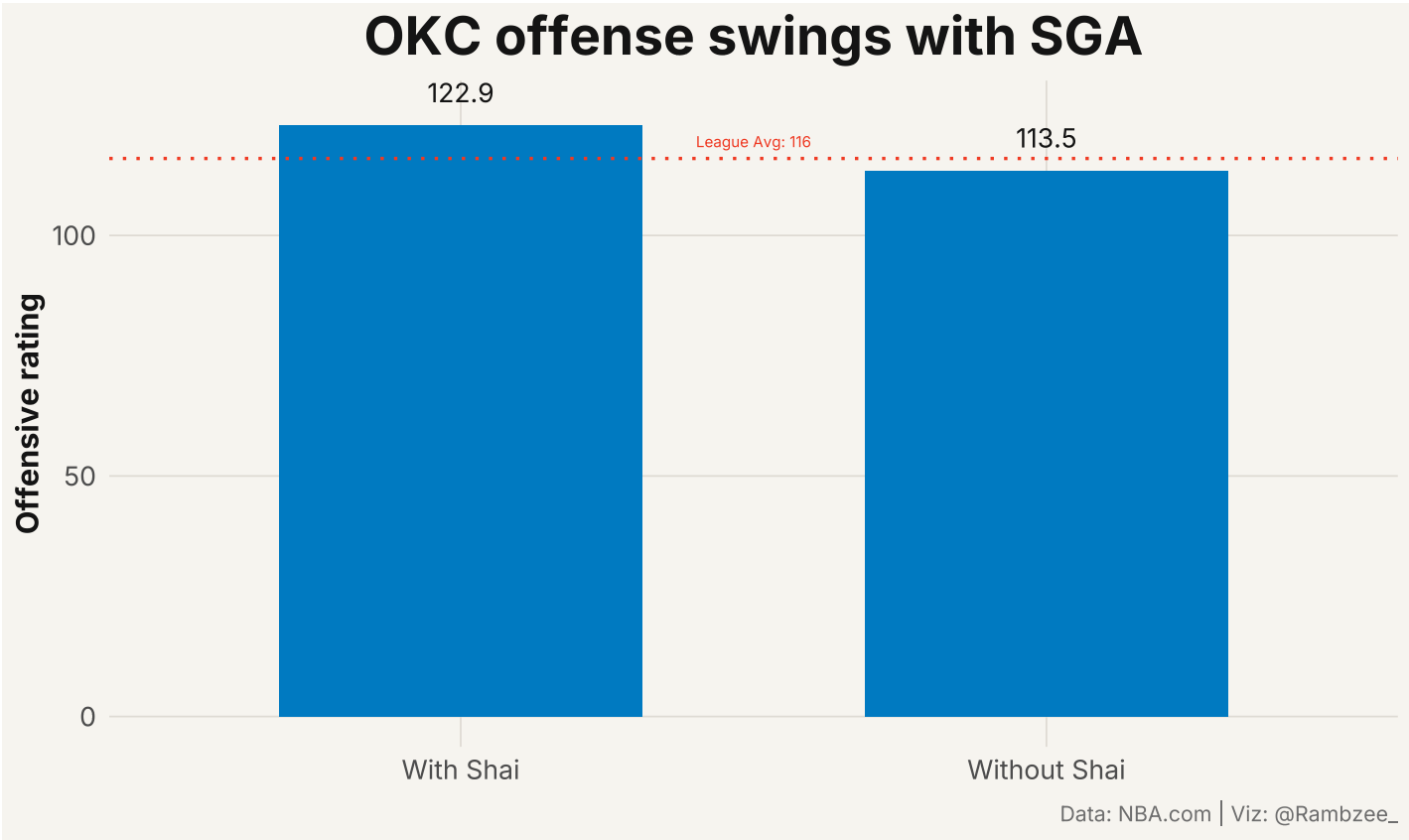
Scenario	PPG	RPG	APG	TS%	rTS	STL	BLK	TOV	Record
Without Jalen Williams	32.2	4.6	6.9	67.3%	+9.2%	1.6	0.7	2.1	35-4
Without Chet Holmgren	30.6	6.1	6.9	62.1%	+4.0%	1.0	1.3	1.8	7-1

Without Jalen Williams, SGA still put up 32.2 points and 6.9 assists per game on 67.3 TS%, and the Thunder went 35-4. Without Chet Holmgren, the efficiency came down some, but the scoring, playmaking, and team results still held up well. That kind of scalability starts with the pressure he puts on a defense every trip down. Shai averaged 18.8 drives per game this season, the most among guards and third-most in the league, and that constant downhill pressure is a big reason the scoring and playmaking keep holding up as the burden rises.

More responsibility usually comes with some trade-off, whether in efficiency, playmaking, or overall team success. With Shai, there was barely one. The scoring stayed elite, the playmaking held up, and Oklahoma City still performed like one of the best teams of the decade whenever he was on the floor.

Team Impact and On-Off Context

State	ORTG	ORTG vs league	DRTG	DRTG vs league
With Shai	122.9	+6.9	106.8	-9.2
Without Shai	113.5	-2.5	107.4	-8.5



Shai is not just making a good offense better. Oklahoma City is already one of the better teams we have seen this decade, which is exactly what makes his impact so striking. Even in the games he has missed, they have still gone 8-4, a reminder that this is not some weak roster being dragged along by one star. It is already a strong team. Shai is the piece that pushes it from very good to all-time great.

Historical Scoring Context

30+ PPG seasons by a guard, ranked by rTS

Year	Age	Player	PPG	rTS
2016	27	Stephen Curry	30.1	13.2%
2021	32	Stephen Curry	32.0	8.9%
2026	27	Shai Gilgeous-Alexander	31.1	8.4%
1989	25	Michael Jordan	32.5	7.7%
1991	27	Michael Jordan	31.5	7.1%
1990	26	Michael Jordan	33.6	6.9%
1988	24	Michael Jordan	35.0	6.6%
2023	32	Damian Lillard	32.2	6.4%
2020	29	Damian Lillard	30.0	6.4%
2018	28	James Harden	30.4	6.4%
2025	26	Shai Gilgeous-Alexander	32.7	6.1%
2020	30	James Harden	34.3	6.1%
2019	29	James Harden	36.1	5.7%
2024	25	Shai Gilgeous-Alexander	30.1	5.6%

This is where the case goes from great to historic. Shai’s +8.4 rTS places him in an absurdly small group for 30-point-per-game guard seasons, trailing only peak Curry and clearing every Michael Jordan season. This is not just elite volume scoring. It is one of the most efficient scoring seasons a guard has ever put together.

30+ PPG seasons with the lowest turnovers per game

Season	PPG	APG	TOV
2025-26 Shai	31.1	6.6	2.2
2023-24 Shai	30.1	6.2	2.2
1995-96 Jordan	30.4	4.3	2.4
2024-25 Shai	32.7	6.4	2.4
1990-91 Jordan	31.5	5.5	2.5

The scoring efficiency is historic on its own. The ball security pushes it even further. High-volume scoring seasons inherently come with some give because of what the role demands. Creating your own shot possession after possession, handling pressure, taking contact, and finishing through bodies naturally leads to mistakes. Shai somehow makes that part of scoring look trivial.

He is taking on a superstar scoring load, creating offense for himself and others, and still barely giving the ball away. Roughly 20 shots a game, more than 6 assists a night, and only 2 turnovers per game is ridiculous possession control. This is not just another great season. It is something only a tiny handful of guards have ever touched, with Jordan being the only real historical comparison that shows up.

FG% Context

Season	Stat line
2025-26 Shai	31.1 PPG (55.3 FG%)
1990-91 Jordan	31.5 PPG (53.9 FG%)
1988-89 Jordan	32.5 PPG (53.8 FG%)
1987-88 Jordan	35.0 PPG (53.5 FG%)
1979-80 Gervin	33.1 PPG (52.8 FG%)
1989-90 Jordan	33.6 PPG (52.6 FG%)
2024-25 Shai	32.7 PPG (51.9 FG%)
2022-23 Shai	31.4 PPG (51.0 FG%)
1981-82 Gervin	32.3 PPG (50.0 FG%)
2023-24 Luka	32.4 PPG (49.6 FG%)
1992-93 Jordan	32.6 PPG (49.5 FG%)

This is not the core of the case, but it is still useful context. The rTS and turnover arguments carry more weight, but the FG% mark adds another layer to the season. Shai now holds the highest FG% ever by a guard averaging 30+, another place where he sits alongside Jordan.

Clutch Impact

Player	PTS	TS%	Record
Shai Gilgeous-Alexander	6.5	67.0%	20-7
Anthony Edwards	5.7	66.6%	14-9
Nikola Jokic	4.8	61.3%	15-17
Stephen Curry	4.5	62.7%	7-10
Jamal Murray	4.4	70.2%	20-18

If the rest of the case was not enough, Shai has also been the best clutch player in basketball. He is averaging 6.5 points per game on 67 TS% in clutch time, the highest mark any player has reached since play-by-play tracking began in 1996. The Thunder are 20-7 in clutch games he has played, and since March 17 he has scored 42 fourth-quarter and overtime points without missing a shot, going 11-for-11 from the field. It is just one more layer of a season that keeps adding to an already historic résumé.

Defensive Impact

Shai's case does not stop on the offensive end. He averaged 1.4 steals and 0.8 blocks this season, good for 2.2 stocks per game, which at the very least reflects how active and disruptive he can be defensively. But the value goes beyond the box score. He is not just a guard who piles up events. He is a legitimately good defender.

That shows up in the team context too. Oklahoma City posted a 106.8 defensive rating with Shai on the floor compared to 107.4 without him. On a team that was already loaded with elite defensive personnel, that is not nothing. If anything, it says even more. He is not being hidden, and he is not just along for the ride. On a historically great defense, he still helps move the needle in the right direction.

Extra Historical Note

Consistency: Shai has already passed Wilt Chamberlain's record for consecutive 20-point games and now sits at 140. Wilt scoring records are supposed to be untouchable, so breaking one says plenty on its own. More than anything, though, it fits the way Shai has always carried himself. His whole game, routine, and approach are built on consistency, and this streak feels like the clearest reflection of that.

Closing

We are watching an all-time great guard add a historic season to an already incredible résumé. Shai is 27 years old, just entering his prime, and already operating at a level very few guards in league history have touched. The efficiency is historic, the ball security is absurd, the shotmaking is elite from every level, and the team impact is exactly what an MVP season is supposed to look like. There are historical comparisons for parts of this season, but the full picture is rare. This is not a breakout or some one-off heater. It is another dominant season from a player whose trophy case is already starting to resemble that of the game's all-time greats, and he will likely add another one soon.